THE BATTLE OF MANILA BAY

On April 27, 1898, Commodore George Dewey, commanding the US Asiatic Squadron anchored in Mirs Bay, China, received a cable from Navy Secretary John D Long: "War has commenced between the United States and Spain. Proceed at once to Philippine islands." Dewey had been expecting this order, but his preparations had been hampered by logistical problems. The nearest US base was in California, and his cruisers had only 60 percent of their optimum ammunition supply—even less than the standard peacetime allotment. Dewey's mission was to attack Spain's fleet in the Philippines, which, it was correctly assumed, would stay inshore, depending on land batteries, for defence against the better-armored, heavier-gunned American ships. Spanish admiral Patricio Montojo originally planned to anchor in Subic Bay, north of Manila, but as shore batteries had negligently not been mounted there, he instead awaited the Americans in Manila Bay. Humane and defeatist, Montojo chose not to fight in front of Manila, where a battle would have caused many civilian casualties. Instead, he anchored off Cavite Naval Yard, in shallow water so that his sailors would have a better chance of survival when their ships sank. Defeating the Americans was not an objective; for Montojo the fight was for the honor of the Spanish Empire.

On the night of April 30, on board the protected cruiser *Olympia*, Commodore Dewey led his squadron into Boca Grande channel, steaming in column with all but stern lights extinguished. Tension was high, for there had been reports that the channel was mined and defended by shore batteries. Their presence was revealed when a support vessel's smokestack flared with fire, but this brought only a brief exchange with guns on El Fraile island. By 1:00 a.m. Dewey's squadron was safely inside Manila Bay.

The battle between the two ill-matched naval squadrons began after dawn. After finding only merchant ships at Manila, Dewey led his cruisers toward Cavite in line ahead, a leadsman calling the depth at *Olympia*'s bow.

> "THE STORM OF SHOT AND SHELL LAUNCHED AGAINST THE SPANIARD WAS DESTRUCTIVE BEYOND ALL DESCRIPTION."
>
> **J.L. STICKNEY**, LIEUTENANT ABOARD *OLYMPIA,* IN A NEWSPAPER ARTICLE, 1898



Flagship Olympia
The protected cruiser USS *Olympia,* Commodore George Dewey's flagship, leads the US battle line in a turn under fire in Manila Bay. American gunnery hammered Spanish ships and shore batteries.